Tianyi Ni

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Research Profile

I am a phonologist who studies synchronic phonological grammars and lexical representations from a diachronic perspective. I ask how sound change, learning, and language transmission shape the emergence and stability of prosodic systems, and whether diachronic mechanisms can explain phonological patterns and typological asymmetries. My work examines phonologization, the roles of children and adults in sound change, and the persistence or loss of contrasts. Empirically, I focus on Germanic and Southeast Asian languages, including Austronesian and Tai languages, with further interests in Tibeto-Burman and Indic languages. I use computational simulation and modeling, mathematical analysis and modeling, cognitive modeling, and corpus analysis.

Research interests: phonology; phonetics; prosodic change; synchronic representation; phonologization; language transmission; contrast stability; phonological typology; Germanic, Austronesian, Tai, Tibeto-Burman, and Indic languages.

Education

2021–present **Ph.D. in Linguistics**, The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH
Dissertation: TBA
Committee: Rebecca L. Morley, Björn Köhnlein, Cynthia Clopper, Karee Garvin

2020–2021 **M.A. in Linguistics**, University of Arizona, Tucson, AZ
Thesis: *The Phonology and Morphology of Siriano: A Grammar Sketch*

2018–2021 **M.S. in Applied Mathematics**, University of Washington, Seattle, WA

2017–2018 **M.S. in Computer Science**, Arizona State University, Tempe, AZ

2012–2016 **B.Eng. in Computer Science**, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Shanghai, China

Publications

Journal Articles and Manuscripts

under review **Ni, Tianyi** & Björn Köhnlein. A metrical analysis of ternary vowel quantity in East Frisian Low German. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*.

in prep. **Ni, Tianyi** & Rebecca L. Morley. A cognitive model for production–perception misalignment. Manuscript in preparation.

in prep. **Ni, Tianyi** & Andrea Sims. Semantic transparency and productivity of modern Khmer compounds and derivational prefixation. Manuscript in preparation.

Conference Proceedings

2026 **Ni, Tianyi** & Rebecca L. Morley. Equilibrium dynamics of near-merger: Functional load effects in Cantonese tone contrast. In *Proceedings of Speech Prosody 2026*. doi:10.21437/SpeechProsody.2026-103.

2025 **Ni, Tianyi**. Bidirectional consonantal effects on F0 realization in Burmese. In *Proceedings of the Third International Conference on Tone and Intonation*. doi:10.21437/TAI.2025-28.

2025 **Ni, Tianyi**, Maike Rocker, & Björn Köhnlein. A metrical analysis of ternary vowel quantity in East Frisian Low German. In *Proceedings of the 2023 and 2024 Annual Meetings on Phonology*, 1(1). doi:10.7275/amphonology.3047.

2021 Chen, Juqiang, **Tianyi Ni**, Benjawan Kasisopa, Mark Antoniou, & Catherine Best. SVM-based evaluation of Thai tone imitations by Thai-naïve Mandarin and Vietnamese speakers. In *Proceedings of the 2021 Asia-Pacific Signal and Information Processing Association Annual Summit and Conference*.

2021 **Ni, Tianyi**. Burmese sandhi-voicing: From the perspective of emergent phonology. *Coyote Papers*, 24, 15.

Thesis

2021 **Ni, Tianyi**. *The Phonology and Morphology of Siriano: A Grammar Sketch*. M.A. thesis, University of Arizona.

Conference Presentations

** Speaker*

2026 Ian Cameron, Phuong Dang, **Tianyi Ni*,** Natalie Bier, Jake Danon, Leena Futoryansky, & Björn Köhnlein. Effects of high- vs. low-variability exposure on the perception of non-native tones. Talk to be presented at *MidPhon31*, Saint Louis University, St. Louis, MO, October 16-17.

2026 **Tianyi Ni*.** Fossilized Prefixes, Living Compounds? Productivity and Semantic Shift in Khmer Word Formation. Talk presented at the *35th Annual Meeting of the Southeast Asian Linguistics Society*, Singapore.

2026 **Tianyi Ni*** & Rebecca L. Morley. Equilibrium dynamics of near-merger: Functional load and contrast persistence. Talk presented at the *20th Conference on Laboratory Phonology*, Montréal, Canada.

2026 **Tianyi Ni** & Rebecca L. Morley. Equilibrium dynamics of near-merger: Functional load effects in Cantonese tone contrast. Poster presented at *Speech Prosody 2026*, Philadelphia, PA.

2025 Björn Köhnlein & **Tianyi Ni*.** Vowels can be shorter before voiced than before voiceless consonants: Reversed durations in two varieties of German. Talk presented at the *31st Manchester Phonology Meeting*, Manchester, UK.

2025 **Tianyi Ni.** Bidirectional consonantal effects on F0 realization in Burmese. Poster presented at the *Third International Conference on Tone and Intonation*, Munich, Germany.

2024 **Tianyi Ni,** Maike Rocker, & Björn Köhnlein. A metrical analysis of ternary vowel quantity in East Frisian Low German. Poster presented at the *Annual Meeting on Phonology*, Rutgers University, NJ.

2022 **Tianyi Ni*.** A domain-driven phonological analysis of sandhi-voicing in Modern Burmese. Talk presented at the *31st Annual Meeting of the Southeast Asian Linguistics Society*, Honolulu, HI.

2022 Yuhong Zhu, Ian Cameron, Rebekah Stanhope, Kate Kinnaird, Yazhao Huang, **Tianyi Ni,** & Björn Köhnlein. Can people learn three levels of sonority-sensitive stress? An online experiment. Poster presented at the *18th Conference on Laboratory Phonology*, online.

Grants, Awards, and Honors

Research Grants

2023 **Ilse Lehiste Memorial Fund Graduate Research Award**, Department of Linguistics, The Ohio State University
Project: Metrical structure in Burmese compound sandhi-voicing

2022 **Graduate & Professional Student Association Research Grant**, Arizona State University
Project: Markov Chain Monte Carlo phylogenetic inference in computational historical linguistics

Awards and Fellowships

2022 Society of Southeastern Asian Linguistics Travel Award, University of Hawai'i at Mānoa

2021–2022 University Fellowship, The Ohio State University

2020–2021 Office of the President Scholarship, Arizona State University

2020 Melikian Center Fellowship, Arizona State University

2020 Graduate & Professional Student Association Research Grant, Arizona State University

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record

Spring 2027 **LING 2000: Introduction to Linguistics**, The Ohio State University

2022–2025 **LING 3902: Language Endangerment and Death**, The Ohio State University

2024 **ENGL 0155: Basic Composition**, Columbus State Community College

2023–2024 **MATH 150: College Algebra**, Franklin University

Other Instructional Experience

2026 **Instructor, North American Computational Linguistics Open Competition**, Metro High School, Columbus, OH
Topic: segmental and suprasegmental phonology for high school students

Fieldwork and Empirical Research Experience

Autumn 2024 **Megrelian language fieldwork**, Columbus, OH
Consultant-based elicitation and analysis of Megrelian segmental phonology and metrical structure.

2022–2023 **Burmese speech fieldwork**, Bloomington, IN
Focus: Burmese tone production.

Technical and Research Skills

Programming and modeling: Python, R, statistical modeling, computational simulation, corpus processing
Linguistic tools: Praat, LaTeX, phonetic analysis, corpus linguistics, fieldwork elicitation
Methods: experimental design, quantitative modeling, corpus-based morphology, computational historical linguistics, phonological analysis

Professional Service

2022 Graduate Student President, Department of Linguistics, The Ohio State University